James Ker, who records how ‘after a short visit to the Paris group he went onto Lausanne where he tried to maintain himself as a teacher of Oriental Languages; here he posed as a Persian, and adopted the Persian alias Mirza Hassna Khan’. [8] Somewhat risibly, he even notes how ‘[a]t the beginning of September, 1914, he left Paris very hurriedly, without even informing his landlady – which is considered a low trick by agents of the secret service in any country – and on September 25th he was at Dakar in Senegal’. [9] As the First World War engulfed Europe, he found himself in Brazil. There he was known to be in close contact with the Ghadar Party in San Francisco. After that, he was back in Europe in time for the Second World War, where he met with Subhas Chandra Bose but was arrested and jailed again after the Axis powers were defeated.

It was through the efforts of Jawaharlal Nehru, as the prospects of Independence loomed, that Ajit Singh returned to India in March 1947. He died in Dalhousie, Punjab (now Himachal Pradesh) on the very day freedom was granted on 15 August 1947. It is said that at his funeral, this sleepy summer hill station, which is located on five hills and still has an old-world charm to it, was thronged by ‘thousands of people’, [10] despite being at an elevation of 1,970 m above sea level; such was the reverence in which Ajit Singh was held. This is remarkable given that his period of exile, from 1909 to 1947, was probably the longest of any freedom fighter at the time, such that he would have been barely even remembered by anyone in India upon his return. Naturally, the period of absence from his family took a heavy toll on them. He was married to Harnam Kaur from Kasur. The two of them lived a life bereft of each other for forty years. During this time, he was unable to come to her aid when she fell ill. It is said that moments before he died, Ajit Singh begged her pardon and told her, ‘I am sorry that I could not serve you in illness.’ He then bowed in front of her, touching her feet and collapsing. [11] A man of heroic stature and true intrinsic human strength—no wonder Bhagat Singh idolized him.

Swaran Singh’s story was equally heart-wrenching. Yet, he is the less well-known of Bhagat Singh’s two uncles. This remains a paradox, because of all the three sons of Arjan Singh, Swaran Singh came to resemble Bhagat